In the midst of this horror, the end of Moscow's military involvement in Afghanistan coincided with Soviet reformers – including Boris Yeltsin – defeating conservative communists in multi-party parliamentary elections in the USSR. Elsewhere, as independence movements gained momentum in the Baltic States, the Hungarian government opened its frontier with Austria on 2 May by dismantling the electric fence along the 240-kilometre boundary – presenting the first crack in the Iron Curtain. The move would have devastating consequences for the GDR. Although concerned, Moscow took no overt actions against Budapest.

Meanwhile, local elections were held across East Germany on 7 May, presenting not so much a spectacle as a sham. Berlin district mayors already knew the results before the vote, as 38-year-old Günter Polauke, one of the youngest mayors in the GDR recounted: 'We already had the election result in our pockets.' As historian Stefan Wolle noted, GDR elections were known to be a farce, 'but almost everyone took part to save themselves trouble.3 What was new on 7 May was that civil rights groups also exercised their right to participate in the public counting of votes.'4 Following the example of the Polish citizens' movement, activists in Berlin, Leipzig, Jena and Erfurt, had spent months preparing the monumental investigative job of vote monitoring – an effort befitting a military operation. Stasi reports, as usual, documented every detail: 'The individuals made notes on the election results announced by the election commissioners, sometimes using previously prepared forms.'5 In almost all constituencies, irregularities, exaggerated results and cases of manipulation of voter turnout were recorded.

In the end, after the ballots closed, Egon Krenz – wearing his chairman of the election commission hat – declared the results in a televised address – an incredible 99 per cent for the SED and their allied parties. It was an 'impressive vote,' he said, which endorsed the 'successful course' of the government and a testament to the SED. But behind this bold front, there was a whiff of Gotterdammerung as ARD and ZDF were already on-air reporting egregious examples of ballot boxes being opened early, falsified voter lists and invalid votes.6 Markus Wolf, the former Stasi operative, who had since resigned, noted the 'rising resentment over the sham electoral procedures that allowed the Socialist Unity Party to continue in power